Spread Love & Acceptance

Understanding yourself and the people you share a life with



The whole book · Short version

All three parts: yourself, between us, and understanding people.

by Christian

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THE WHOLE BOOK · SHORT VERSION

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spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance: The whole book, the short version.
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Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counselor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

The examples are made up. The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

Research mentioned in the chapters is listed, with links, in the research notes at the back and at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

How to use this book

This is a book about seeing what is really going on, in yourself and between people, without blaming anyone, and then changing one small thing. This copy holds 26 chapters in three parts, in the short version. There is no wrong way in.

THE PARTS

Part One: Self-discovery. Where you came from, who you are now and who you are becoming. You can read all of it on your own.

Part Two: Between us. One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.

Part Three: Understanding people. How feelings, stress, trust, change, grief, groups and love work, for anyone, in any kind of relationship.

TWO SIZES OF EVERY CHAPTER

Every chapter comes in a short version (about 10 to 15 minutes) and a full version with the research, more examples and more to try. This is the short version. The full version is free at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book.

READ IN ORDER, OR BY NEED

Read it front to back like any book, or start with the chapter that fits what is going on. Each chapter ends with *What to remember*, *This connects to* (the chapters that explain it or put it to use, with page numbers) and *Put it to use*, with codes you can scan for the matching tool.

IN EVERY CHAPTER

- A short scene: a made-up moment from everyday life.
- **Words you could use**: sentences to say out loud.
- **Try this**: one small thing to do this week.
- **Common mix-ups**: easy mistakes, and what is closer to true.

THE SITE, THE PROGRAM AND PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The book has a free website with the workpapers (pages you fill in) and tools (helpers you use) that the chapters mention; the next page explains both. Nothing you type there leaves your device, and there is no account. The **six-week program** (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01) puts Part Two to work a week at a time, and the **self path** does the same for Part One. **Professor Puddles**, the site's friendly guide, answers questions about the book's ideas.

GO GENTLY

Some chapters touch hard things: grief, shame, anger, worry, trauma. Skip anything that isn't right for today. Nothing here is a test, and nothing needs to be done all at once.

Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **Workpapers: pages you fill in**

A workpaper is a page you fill in, on your own or together: a one-week log, a list of who owns which job, a short check. Each one has a number, like **WP-03**, and it is always called a workpaper, for example “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. The blank workpapers are also at the back of this book, one page each, to copy.

TOOL **Tools: helpers you use on the site**

A tool is an interactive helper on the website: a quiz, a calm-down timer, a card maker, or the Chat analyzer that reads a message with you. You use it and it gives you something back. It is always called a tool, for example “Tool: Chat analyzer”.

The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Three friends who give hints



Professor Puddles, the site’s cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints: a thought to take with you, and the workpaper or tool that fits.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup with the big smile and the collar, bounds in now and then with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup with the long soft ears and the best hugs, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

Find it fast

Start with what is going on, not with chapter one. Each line points to the place in the book that helps most, and one tool to try. You can read that part on its own and stop.

SHARING THE LOAD

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
We keep arguing about chores.	Part Two · Chapter II · One owner per job	18	WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job
I do the remembering and planning, and nobody sees it (the mental load).	Preface to Part Two · The mental load		WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what
We each think we do more than our share.	Preface to Part Two · Why the other person doesn't see it		WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what
The same job keeps slipping, week after week.	Part Two · Chapter V · A repeat usually has no real owner		WORKPAPER WP-04 What keeps coming back?
Is the way we share things fair? Can it last?	Part Two · Chapter II · The setup score	18	TOOL Is the setup working for everyone?
We've just had a baby and we're both exhausted.	Part Two · Chapter II · Small children and a new baby	32	WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying?
We're about to move in together.	Part Two · Chapter V · Starting out: before you move in		TOOL The "Who does what?" page
Money between us feels unfair.	Part Two · Chapter IV · Money between you		TOOL Who does what? The Money tab
We co-parent across two homes.	Part Two · Chapter III · Two homes		WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job
We share a house with a roommate, or more than two of us share a home.	Part Two · Chapter IV · A couple and a roommate		TOOL The "Who does what?" page

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
I'm raising my grandchild (kinship care).	Part Two · Chapter V · Raising a grandchild		WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job
Faith matters to us, or family elders expect a say.	Part Two · Chapter I · Faith, culture and family voices		WORKPAPER WP-13 The 90-second daily check-in
I'm caring for a parent or partner, and it's wearing me down.	Part Three · Chapter 12 · Your limits make your help last		WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying?
I'm the only one who wants to try this.	Part Two · Chapter II · When only one of you is on board	35	WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what (your side only)
Someone handed me this book, and I'm not sure why.	If someone handed you this book	10	WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job

TALKING IT THROUGH

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
Small things turn into big fights.	Part Two · Chapter I · How stress changes your frequency		WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit
One of us goes quiet and the other pushes for an answer.	Part Three · Chapter 5 · Feeling safe with someone		WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit: our pause plan
Texts and messages keep landing wrong.	Part Three · Chapter 4 · Messages lose their tone		TOOL Chat analyzer
We move and talk at different speeds.	Part Two · Chapter I · What sets the frequency		WORKPAPER WP-12 Same moment, different speeds
A comment stings and I snap back.	Part Two · Chapter IV · Let a comment land before you react		WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands
We need to say sorry and mend things.	Part Three · Chapter 11 · A real apology		WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands
Conflict at work, with a colleague or in a team.	Part Three · Chapter 4 · Saying hard things kindly		WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands
Is it us, or is it everything else going on?	Part Two · Chapter III · Leftover stress		WORKPAPER WP-14 Is it us, or is it everything else?

KNOWING YOURSELF

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
I can't tell what I'm feeling.	Part One · Now · When feelings are hard to name		TOOL My weather today
I'm wiped out and everything feels like too much.	Part One · Now · Check your weather; one state, many words		WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying?
ADHD: I'm overwhelmed and keep forgetting things.	Part Three · Chapter 9 · ADHD, time and motivation		TOOL "How to talk to me" card
I'm autistic, and people keep misreading me (or I misread them).	Part One · Now · A mix-up runs both ways		TOOL "How to talk to me" card
Old rules from childhood still run my reactions.	Part One · Then · Write down the rulebook from home		The self path: where your lens came from
My inner critic is loud.	Part Three · Chapter 7 · The critic and the soothing system		WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit
I want to change a habit, but it keeps slipping.	Part One · Next · Tiny, repeatable steps		The self path, step by step

HARD SEASONS

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
Someone I love has died.	Part Three · Chapter 8 · Grief comes in waves		When you've lost someone
I feel lonely, or I live on my own.	Part Three · Chapter 5 · Building connection from where you are		Living on your own, living well
A teenager's anger, or I'm a teenager and I'm angry.	Part Three · Chapter 13 · The hot minutes		WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit
Left out of a group, a friend group or a group chat.	Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups online, and their pull		TOOL Chat analyzer
Worry keeps me awake, or my mood is low.	Part Three · Chapter 16 · Worry time; low mood		WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying?

Each thing to try is marked as a workpaper (a page you fill in) or a tool (a helper you use on the site). All are free on the website, with nothing to sign up for; each chapter's end has a code you can scan for them. Looking for a word rather than a problem? The index at the back lists the main ideas.

If someone handed you this book

Maybe it was left on your side of the bed with a page turned down. Maybe someone said, "Could you just read this bit?" Either way, you didn't choose it. Fair enough. Here is the short version, written for you.

This isn't a case against you

The book starts from something researchers have found again and again: when two people each estimate their share of the housework, the two answers usually add up to more than 100%. Nobody is lying. You see every minute of your own effort and only some of theirs, and so do they (Chapter II, page **18**). So the book never asks who the bad guy is. Its numbers score the setup, never a person.

What's in it for you

- Fewer repeat arguments about the same jobs.
- Jobs that are clearly yours, so nobody needs to remind you about them.
- Credit for what you already do. Your jobs go on the list too: the car, the trash, the late-night lifts, the things you fix.
- A say in what "fair" means in your house. It isn't always 50/50 (Chapter IV, page).

It doesn't ask for therapy talk, and you never fill anything in about the other person. You can say no.

A first week: three small things

1. **Log your own week.** Rough minutes on "Who did what," including the thinking part: booking, remembering, planning. Ten minutes in all. Only yours, never theirs.
2. **Ask one question, and just listen.** "What's the one job you'd most like to stop thinking about?" Don't defend or count. Write the answer down.
3. **Take over that job, the whole of it,** including the noticing (below).

Words to open the talk

> "I read the bit you gave me. I don't agree with all of it, but I get the point about the stuff nobody sees."
> "I'd rather own a couple of things properly than 'help' with everything. Which one would you most like off your mind?"
> "Give me a week to see what I actually do. Then let's look together."

Best left out, for now: "Just tell me what to do" (it hands the thinking straight back), "You should have asked" and, in the first five minutes, "I do loads too." That may be true. Save it for when you both have your logs.

Taking over a whole job, noticing included

Every job has a part you can see (doing it) and parts you can't: noticing it needs doing, remembering, planning and checking it got done (the Preface, page). Taking a job over means all of it.

1. **Pick one job that repeats:** the children's clothes and shoes, the trash, the car, school forms, the dentist.
2. **Get the handover once.** What it involves, when it's due, where things are, who to call. Ask your questions now, not every week.
3. **Move the remembering out of their head.** A phone reminder, the calendar, a list on the fridge: anywhere but the other person.
4. **Do it start to finish for a month** without being reminded. If you need reminding, fix your reminder, not the relationship.
5. **Do it your way.** If the result is fine, the method is yours. Their part is to let it be done differently.
6. **Ask for a backstop if you like:** someone who notices a slip and says so once, kindly. A backstop isn't a supervisor (Chapter II, page **18**).

A made-up example. Hester has always looked after the children's clothes: spotting toes at the end of shoes, school sizes, swimming kit, passing on what's outgrown. Wilf takes it over. Hester writes the handover note: sizes, the shop, which drawer holds the next size up. Wilf sets a reminder for the first Sunday of each month: "Shoes, uniform, kit." In week two he misses the gym clothes for a school trip. Hester says once, "The trip kit is Thursday," and he adds "school letters" to his Sunday check. A month in, Hester says the biggest change is that she no longer thinks about shoes at eleven at night.

If you think it's already fair

Log your week anyway. If it comes out even, that is useful to know, and the book will say so: a fair score doesn't silence anyone, and a low one doesn't blame anyone. And if this book feels like the wrong place to start, Find it fast, page **7** lists other ways in.

The book in two pictures

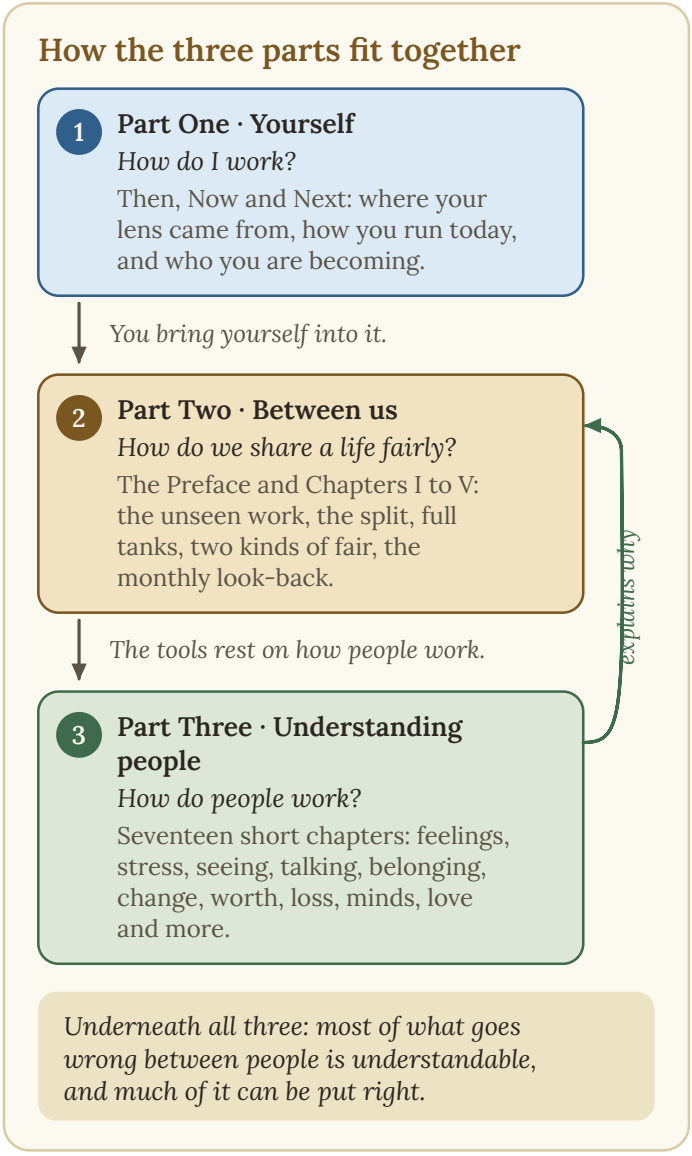


FIGURE 1 How the three parts fit together: you bring yourself into every shared life, and Part Three explains why the Part Two tools work.

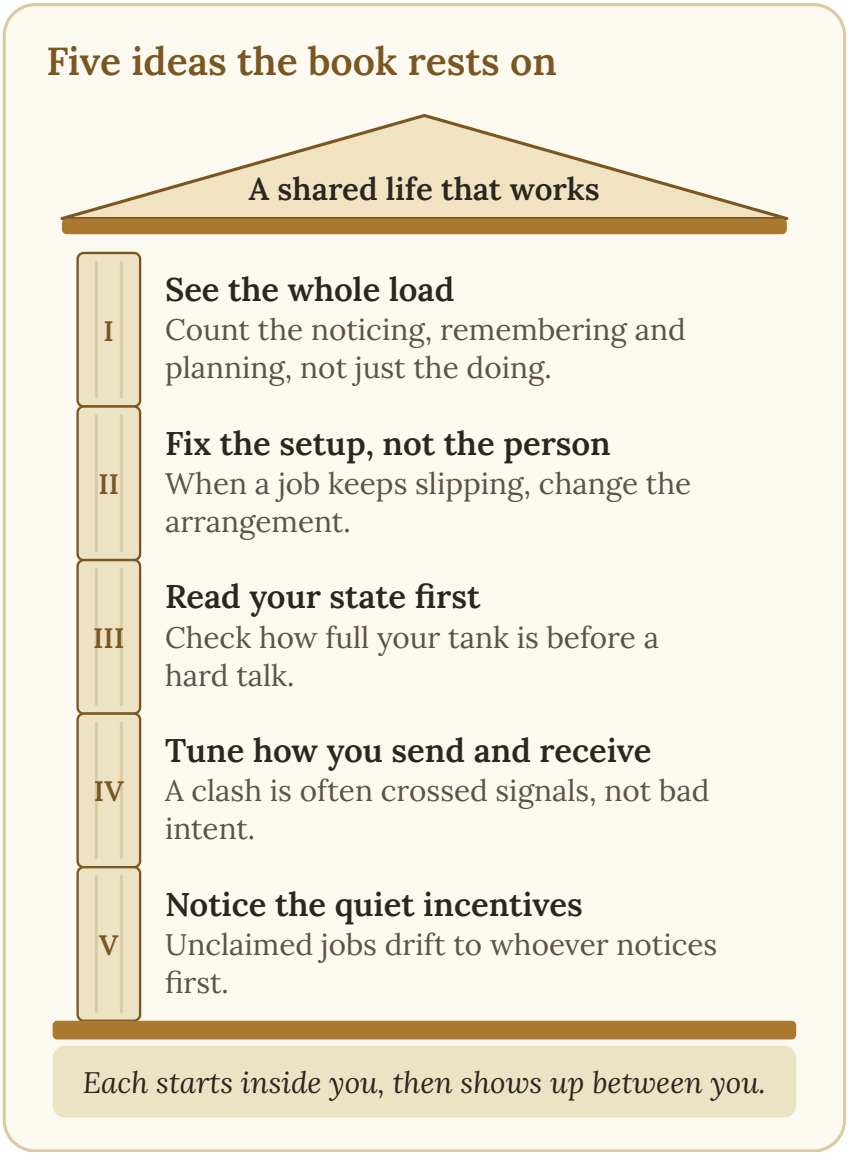


FIGURE 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on. Each one starts inside you, then shows up between you and the people you share a life with.

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PART TWO

Between us

One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.

IN THIS PART

Chapter II Is the split working? 18



TIDBIT

This part comes with workpapers to fill out, together or on your own. If you only try one, make it the one-week log.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01

II

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home

One gentle question: can the way you share the work keep going, or is one of you quietly running on empty?

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Look at the month, not last night
2. Three things go in
3. Balance: how the hours split
4. Ownership: does each job have a name?
5. Stress: how full each stress tank is
6. One number comes out, from 0 to 1
7. Start with the biggest shortfall
8. It judges the setup, never a person
9. Words this chapter uses
10. On your own: is your own load working?
11. One setup, looked at twice
12. Common mix-ups
13. Small children and a new baby
14. If only one of you wants to try this
15. More for your situation

AT A GLANCE

- **Look at the month, not last night**, using what you both wrote down.
- **Three things go in**, which are how the hours split, whether each job has a name, and how full each person's stress tank is.
- **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.
- **It judges the setup, never a person**, and it is where a talk starts.

ANY GIVEN WEEK

One of you is quietly doing eleven small things a day that the other has never had to think about, like the trash schedule and the fish food, the reply to the school, the dentist reminder, and the bit at the bottom of the shopping list that just says "bulbs?"

When the other one says it feels pretty even, they mean it. From inside their own week, it does.

Eleven small jobs a day, seen quickly. On the surface, a split that feels even to one person. Underneath, jobs with no owner. Underneath that, stress tanks at very different levels. The roots are ownership and structure, and quiet incentives. Then the chapter takes the three parts of the score in turn.

01

Look at the month, not last night.

Ask whether the split is working and the answer usually comes from whatever happened most recently, which is usually last night's pans. This chapter asks a calmer question, using what you both wrote down. Ask it again every few months, even when things seem fine, because a split that worked once can quietly go stale.

Two roommates had one truly terrible week of dishes in May, the kind where you wash a fork in order to eat with it. They were all set for a big fight. Then they looked at the whole month, written down, and it was three ordinary weeks and one exam week. The fight didn't happen, which was almost a disappointment after all that build-up. They bought paper plates for exam week and left it at that.



SUGARFOOT

One bad evening isn't the whole story. Give it a month, then run the check together, slowly, with something to eat.

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working

02

Three things go in.

The first is how evenly the hours are shared. The second is whether every regular job has a clear owner, from the job list in One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job). The third is how stressed each of you already is from everything else going on. A **workpaper** is one of the site's free fill-in worksheets. You don't need any of them to start, since rough notes on the back of an envelope do fine.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "Let's each bring our own numbers, so neither of us has to guess."

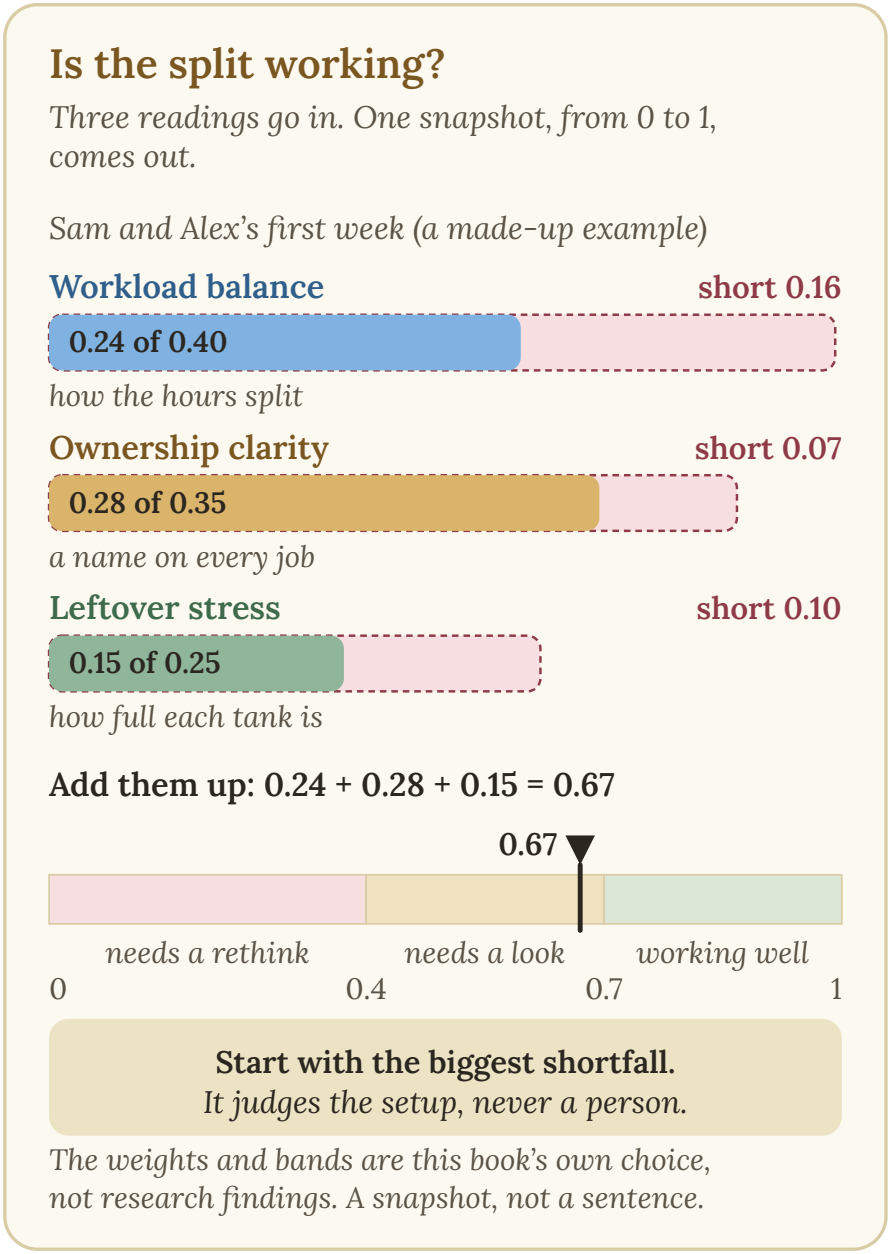


FIGURE 13 Is the split working? Three readings go in and one snapshot comes out. Start with the biggest shortfall. It judges the setup, never a person.

03

Balance: how the hours split.

From your week-long logs, work out each person's share of the hours. An even split scores 1 and one person doing everything scores 0, whichever person it is. If you've agreed an uneven split that suits you, perhaps because one of you works longer hours outside the home, compare against that split instead. With three or more of you, compare each person's share with an even share (100 divided by the number of people) or with the split you agreed. Three partners who log 30 hours of home jobs between them, at 15, 9 and 6, would each have 10 as an even share. The "Who does what?" page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand), where each person lists their hours, does the arithmetic for you.

Log one week each, and put in the small jobs that take under ten minutes. Those are the ones that go missing. They are often the ones that start the fights, too.

Everyone's share comes to more than 100%

In a classic set of experiments, spouses asked for their own share of joint jobs gave answers that, added together, usually came to more than 100%. Nobody was lying. We simply remember our own contributions better, which is the best argument I know for writing the week down instead of guessing.

Ross and Sicoly (1979) · *Strong: a classic, widely replicated finding*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

Who does what? Quick look

Wren, Josh and Mei, roommates (Wren's view)

Quick look: who does what at home

Mark who mostly does each job. The picture builds as you go, the thinking work too.

Your name	Their name
Wren	*Josh*
Person 3	
Mei	

Job	Who mostly does it
Dishes	*Shared*
Laundry	*Shared*
Cleaning the bathroom	*Josh*
Cooking dinner	*Mei*
Grocery shopping	*Wren*
Paying bills	*Wren*
Noticing what's running low	*Wren*
Planning the week	*Mei*
Remembering dates and appointments	*Wren*

HOW IT LOOKS

Here's how it looks from your side, 9 jobs so far.

Everyday jobs: mostly shared. 6 jobs: Wren 2 · Josh 1 · Mei 1 · Shared 2.

Planning and remembering: mostly Wren. 3 jobs: Wren 2 · Mei 1.

The thinking work is easy to miss, because nobody sees it happen. Saying it out loud is a good start.

Does this match how it feels to the three of you?

Made-up example. Pets and booking appointments were taken off the list: they don't happen in this house.

Fill in your own: Who does what? Quick look (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

04

Ownership: does each job have a name?

Each job gets two names. The owner does the job from start to finish. The backstop notices if it slipped and checks in gently, which is very different from supervising. It can be the same person, though a second name gives the job a gentle check. Count the jobs that have an owner and divide by all the

jobs on the list, and leave the unowned jobs on the list, because they matter most. A *decision* you make together, such as which school, can be marked "Both (decide together)" and counts as owned. A *job* that needs doing gets one name.

Most of what goes wrong in shared work isn't incompetence. It's unclear ownership: work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one, and it quietly lands on whoever notices first.

Two sisters care for their dad. Nobody owned his prescription refills. For two weeks each of them thought the other had ordered it, and each, it turned out, had thought about calling to check and hadn't, so as not to seem pushy. He ran out on a Sunday. The late-night pharmacy was forty minutes away.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

A job without a name tends to land on whoever notices first. Write one owner next to each job, and the guessing stops.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03

05

Stress: how full each stress tank is.

Each of you rates how full your own stress tank is with How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying), where a higher score means more stress. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 is medium, and 0.60 or more is high. The score uses the average of your two scores, but if either of you is at 0.60 or more, talk about that first, even when the overall result looks fine. A setup that only works when you're both well rested can't last, so more stress lowers the result.

Doreen is raising her two grandchildren and scores 0.70. Her son, who helps on weekends, scores 0.35. The average looks fine, but Doreen's 0.70 is the headline, whatever the average says, and her son, looking at the two numbers side by side, went quiet for a long time. Each of you scores your own tank on the same day, before you look at the other's.

How loaded it feels

The Perceived Stress Scale, one of the most used stress questionnaires, asks how unpredictable, uncontrollable and overloaded life has felt lately, and its scores track symptoms of depression and illness. That's close to what the stress tank asks: not how much happened, but how loaded it feels.

Cohen, Kamarck and Mermelstein (1983) · *Strong: one of the most widely used stress questionnaires*

06

One number comes out, from 0 to 1.

A result of 0.70 or above reads as *working well*, meaning the setup is holding. From 0.40 up to 0.70 it reads as *needs a look*, because something is drifting, often who owns what, and below 0.40 it reads as *needs a rethink, together*. The result is called the setup score. It is a simple weighted sum, in which the hours count most, then the owners, then stress, and although it looks like a probability it isn't one.

Two friends who run a café together scored 0.55. So nothing was broken, just something drifting, and it took them about four minutes to find it, which was the Monday ordering. Each of them had assumed for months that the other did it, and it had been getting done, more or less, by whoever panicked first on Tuesday morning. Write the date next to your number, so you can compare next month.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

Is the setup working for everyone?

Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years

Is the setup working for everyone?

Person 1 (optional)
Rosemary

Person 2 (optional)
Ken

1. How the hours split

From Who did what or the "Who does what?" page: each person's total hours for the week.

Rosemary, hours
14

Ken, hours
10

2. Does each job have a name?

From One owner per job.

Jobs on the list
12

Jobs with an owner
9

3. How much each person is carrying

Each person's own score from How much are you carrying? Everyone fills in their own.

Rosemary, load (0 to 1)
0.45

Ken, load (0 to 1)
0.30

HOW THE SETUP IS WORKING

Working well
0.75 of 1. The setup is carrying its own weight.

Next: nothing in the setup needs changing this week. Keep the same rhythm of check-ins.

If you want to nudge it higher one day (optional, not urgent): hand about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken, and balance would go from 0.83 to 1.00. Give one more job an owner (the person who does it and sees it through), and ownership would go from 0.75 to 0.83.

It scores the setup, never a person, and never the relationship as a whole.

Fill in your own: Is the setup working for everyone?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/calculators/is-the-setup-working-quick)

07

Start with the biggest shortfall.

The single number matters less than which of the three parts pulled it down most. The **shortfall** is how far one part fell below the most it could add, and in the middle band it's often ownership, which is why the calculator suggests One owner per job first. A separated couple scored 0.62 and found their biggest gap was that nobody owned the school forms. That was the only thing they changed that month, and both of them were quietly relieved it wasn't something bigger.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Which part pulled the number down most? Let's start there."

08

It judges the setup, never a person.

The number isn't a verdict on who's better or whether the relationship works. It's where a conversation starts, never how one ends.

"So I'm the problem," said Lee, looking at 0.35.

"No," said his partner. "The bathroom hasn't got an owner and you work nights."

They started there. Before you begin, agree that either of you can say "pause" and come back later.

When a measure becomes a target
Goodhart's law, from an economist writing about monetary policy, says a number tends to stop telling you anything once people are pushed to hit it. That's the reason this score is for looking at together and never for winning.

Goodhart (1975) · *Moderate: an economist's observation, later generalized and widely seen in practice*

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. The score describes the setup you share, but your levers are your own: your jobs, your hours and what you agree to take on. You can propose a fix; you can't make the other person accept it. If the balance stays one-sided, step your load back toward your share on purpose, and say so kindly. Matching effort with effort protects your stress tank, and your tank is part of the score too. More in Your wiring, weather and words

SUNDAY EVENING

Two week-long logs. Two cups of tea. One list has 31 rows and the other has 18, and for a moment neither of you says anything and the fridge hums.

"I honestly didn't know about half of these," one of you says.

"Which half?"

Words this chapter uses

A **log** is a simple list of the jobs you did this week and roughly how long each took. The **owner** does a job from start to finish, including remembering it, and the **backstop** notices if a job slipped and checks in gently. Your **stress tank** is how much stress you're already carrying from the rest of life. The **setup** is the way you share the work right now, which can always be changed, and the **setup score** is the one number from 0 to 1 that sums up the three

readings. Invisible jobs count too. Planning meals, remembering birthdays, booking the vet and noticing that the soap is running low all belong in your log.

On your own: is your own load working?

You can ask the same question of your own week. Are you spending more energy than comes back? Add up what you carry, jobs and worries both, and set it beside what refills you. If it runs in the red, change your side, by dropping, delaying, asking or saying no kindly. A limit describes your supply. It says nothing about your worth. After her breakup, Leanne had the children every other week and filled the quiet weeks with favors for friends, including one memorable assemble-it-yourself dresser that took nine hours and a hospital visit (her thumb). Writing it down showed her she never rested (more in On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'd love to help, and I can't this week. Can I let you know next week?"

One setup, looked at twice

Three people share an apartment above a bakery, and everyone agrees that cleaning matters while nobody owns the bathroom. Their first check scores 0.67, and the biggest shortfall is ownership: eight of the twelve jobs have a name, and the bathroom, the trash, the recycling and the hallway don't. They give each of those four jobs an owner and a backstop. A month later, with the hours and their stress tanks about the same as before, the score is 0.79. Ownership went from 0.67 to 1.00, and that part counts for 0.35 of the score, so it adds 0.12. The bathroom is better. The recycling is still a sore point, because the one who owns it works late on collection night, and that's the job they're arguing about next. Shift work, illness and caring can all make hours look even while sleep or energy is not, and an uneven split agreed on purpose can be the fair one (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours, and When one of you is sick or disabled, spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

Redoing a job, two ways

Some people care most that a job got done. Others care how it was done, because things have a system and a cup in the "wrong" place means hunting for it later. If you care that it's done, a quiet reload of the dishwasher can feel like your work was graded. If you care about the system, saying the reason ("The bowls go at the back so the door shuts") turns a silent redo into a plan you can share.

Where the fields meet. Politics would say a home is a small government, and a rule lasts when the people who live by it helped make it. That is why the score is filled in together, from both people's own notes. The roots are ownership and structure, and quiet incentives.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 10

Our room agreement

Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates

Our room agreement

Your name
Kayla

Their name
Bea

Quiet hours
11pm to 7am on weeknights, midnight on Fridays and Saturdays. Headphones after that.

Guests (daytime)
Fine with a quick text first. Not during the other one's study or sleep time.

Overnight guests

Up to 2 nights a week, agreed the day before. A guest doesn't stay in the room when their host isn't there.

Cleaning

Kayla: floor and trash cans, Sunday. Bea: desk area and the fridge, Wednesday. Our own laundry, our own job.

Borrowing

Ask first, every time. Food on the shared shelf is for both of us.

Lights and alarms

Big light off by 11:30 on weeknights; a desk lamp is fine. One alarm, one snooze at most.

How we bring up problems

Text first if that's easier, then talk within a few days, one topic at a time. If we're stuck, we ask our RA to help.

YOUR AGREEMENT, READY TO SEND

Our room agreement (Kayla and Bea), with every line above, ending: "We'll look at it again together in a month."

They kept most of the site's starting point and changed two lines.

Fill in your own: Our room agreement (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)

Common mix-ups

A low number doesn't mean the relationship is failing. It means the current setup needs changing, and setups change all the time. Please don't guess the numbers. A guessed number is a feeling with a decimal point, so use your written logs. One of you can't fill it out for both, either. Each person writes their own log and scores their own stress tank. And fair doesn't have to mean exactly 50/50. Fair is what you both agree to with your eyes open, and an uneven split you chose together can be the fair one. Two kinds of fair looks at this.

Small children and a new baby

Small children bring a flood of new jobs, and most of them are thinking jobs, from the daycare bag and the shots to the party invitations, the next size of clothes and the nights. That's why the mental load (see the work nobody sees) often grows after a baby arrives, usually without anyone deciding it. Log the children's jobs too, with the thinking time, and count the nights. Hand over whole jobs, like clothes and sizes or the doctor and the shots, so the new owner does the noticing too, in their own way. If a baby is on the way, write your first job list together before the birth, plan the nights, and agree to look again at six weeks, at three months and before either of you goes back to work. In the first weeks, share by energy more than by hours, so whoever was up in the night gets the rest.

Hollie and Gareth have Alfie, who is three, and Poppy, who is eight months, and Gareth is a paramedic on shifts. Their logged minutes came out nearly even, yet Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked for. They left the minutes alone and moved one whole job, the children's clothes, to Gareth. In the first two weeks Alfie went to daycare in a vest in October. Hollie said nothing, heroically.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "Could you own the daycare bag from now on, including noticing when we're low on diapers? I won't check it."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 11

Who did what, with small children

Hollie and Gareth, parents of a toddler and a baby; Gareth works shifts

Who did what

Person A
Hollie

Person B
Gareth

Week beginning
October 12, 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Pack the daycare bag: spare clothes, diapers, named milk*	*Hollie*	10	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Book Poppy's one-year shots at the doctor*	*Hollie*	15	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Bath and bedtime, both children*	*Gareth*	45	*Asked for*
Wed	*Reply to a party invite and buy the present*	*Hollie*	25	*Noticed and handled*
Wed	*Sort outgrown clothes and order the next size*	*Hollie*	40	*Noticed and handled*
Thu	*Plan the week's meals around Gareth's nights*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*
Thu	*Cook dinner and batch-cook for the weekend*	*Gareth*	75	*Noticed and handled*
Fri	*Remember the daycare photo money and form*	*Hollie*	10	*Thinking and planning*

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Fri	*Night wakings with Poppy*	*Hollie*	60	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Swimming lesson with Alfie*	*Gareth*	60	*Asked for*
Sat	*Big grocery run and diapers*	*Both*	80	*Asked for*
Sun	*Laundry for both children, to put away*	*Hollie*	50	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Fix the stair gate*	*Gareth*	20	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Update the family calendar and the childcare schedule*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Hollie
290 minutes (55%), of which 250 noticed and handled without being asked (50 of them thinking and planning)

Gareth
240 minutes (45%), of which 95 noticed and handled without being asked

Workload balance score
0.91. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Hollie did 72% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.

Gareth worked three night shifts this week, so his rows are fewer; the minutes

are close, and the noticing is the part to talk about.

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

If only one of you wants to try this

That's common, and you can still start. Log your own week, score your own tank, and then share one small thing you noticed, without asking the other person to agree with your numbers. A dad noticed he was spending five hours a week driving his sixteen-year-old to training and back. He said so, without any accusation in it, and they agreed on a bus pass for two days a week. His son grumbled for two weeks and then started to enjoy the bus, where nobody asked him how training went. Share one finding at a time, then let it rest for a few days.

If the other person refuses to talk about the split at all, ever, that isn't a setup problem, and no score will fix it.

More for your situation

Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · For counselors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

To run the check, each of you first logs one week in Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01), because the number only means something if you each wrote your own. Next, fill out the job list in One owner per job together, including any jobs nobody owns yet, and each score your own stress tank on the same day. Put the three numbers into the

calculator (spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working), look first at the biggest shortfall, pick one small change together and check again in a month.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees
The unseen work the check counts — online

Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles
The stress input, explained — online

Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change
Fixing the setup with small, kind changes — online

Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well
When one person carries the care — online

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 2: give every job one owner
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01
In: The work nobody sees (page), Is the split working? (page **18**), The monthly look-back (page)

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02
In: Your wiring, weather and words (page), Is the split working? (page **18**), Full tanks and different angles (page), The monthly look-back (page), Stress and the nervous system (page), Helping others well (page)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03
In: Is the split working? (page **18**), Two kinds of fair (page), The monthly look-back (page), Habits and change (page), Helping others well (page), Groups, influence and culture (page)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04
In: Who you are becoming (page), The monthly look-back (page)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09
In: Why we get out of tune (page), Two kinds of fair (page), How communication works (page), Groups, influence and culture (page)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11
In: Your wiring, weather and words (page), Who you are becoming (page), Full tanks and different angles (page), How feelings work (page), Stress and the nervous system (page), Anger (page), Worry, low mood and trauma (page)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13
In: Why we get out of tune (page), Habits and change (page)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15
In: Attachment, trust and belonging (page), Values, meaning and a good life (page), Closeness and love (page)

WORKPAPERS **All the workpapers, to fill out on screen or print** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill

In: What the book adds up to (page)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Chat analyzer** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/signal-translator

In: How we see each other (page), How communication works (page), Groups, influence and culture (page)

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

In: Why we get out of tune (page), Full tanks and different angles (page), How we see each other (page), How communication works (page), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page), Healing after hurt (page)

TOOL **Say no kindly: make your scripts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals

In: Helping others well (page)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: make a pause plan** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

In: Stress and the nervous system (page), Attachment, trust and belonging (page), Anger (page)

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

In: The monthly look-back (page), How communication works (page), Helping others well (page), Groups, influence and culture (page)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

In: Two kinds of fair (page), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page), Worry, low mood and trauma (page)

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

In: How feelings work (page), Attachment, trust and belonging (page), Closeness and love (page)

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page), Closeness and love (page)

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

In: Where your lens came from (page), Your wiring, weather and words (page), Who you are becoming (page), Personality, temperament and change (page)

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page), How communication works (page), Minds that work differently (page), Personality, temperament and change (page), Groups, influence and culture (page)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

In: Where your lens came from (page), Full tanks and different angles (page), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page), Values, meaning and a good life (page)

TOOL **Rhythms side by side** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration

In: Why we get out of tune (page)

TOOL **Who does what? Quick look** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand

In: The work nobody sees (page)

TOOL **Who does what? Count the hours and bills** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand

In: Is the split working? (page **18**), Two kinds of fair (page)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: Upset right now?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

In: How feelings work (page), Stress and the nervous system (page), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page), Loss, grief and big life changes (page), Healing after hurt (page), Anger (page), Worry, low mood and trauma (page)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

In: Anger (page)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

In: Stress and the nervous system (page), Loss, grief and big life changes (page), Worry, low mood and trauma (page)

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page), Full tanks and different angles (page), How feelings work (page)

TOOL **My weather today: the sky (the ladder)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Why we get out of tune (page), Full tanks and different angles (page), Stress and the nervous system (page), Healing after hurt (page)

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page), Loss, grief and big life changes (page), Healing after hurt (page)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page), Values, meaning and a good life (page), Helping others well (page), What the book adds up to (page)

TOOL **Read your way** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

In: Minds that work differently (page)

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

In: Who you are becoming (page), Habits and change (page)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

In: Who you are becoming (page), Is the split working? (page **18**), Full tanks and different angles (page), Two kinds of fair (page), The monthly look-back (page), How we see each other (page), How communication works (page), Healing after hurt (page)

TOOL **Plan it once: room agreement for roommates** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

In: Who you are becoming (page), Full tanks and different angles (page), Two kinds of fair (page), The monthly look-back (page), How communication works (page), Minds that work differently (page), Personality, temperament and change (page)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

In: Is the split working? (page **18**), Attachment, trust and belonging (page), Habits and change (page), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page), Values, meaning and a good life (page), Helping others well (page), Anger (page), Personality, temperament and change (page), Worry, low mood and trauma (page), Groups, influence and culture (page)

TOOL **Ten-minute start** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes

In: Who you are becoming (page), What the book adds up to (page)

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working

In: Is the split working? (page **18**)

How the numbers work

Every number in this book is arithmetic you can do with a pencil. None of them is a test, a diagnosis or a verdict on anyone: they describe a week, a load or a way of sharing work. The weights and cut-offs are this book's own rules of thumb, not research findings, and you are free to disagree with them. The worked examples are the book's own, so you can check them against the chapters.

Two habits run through all of them. **Scores are rounded to two decimal places before their band is read,** so the number you see and the words you see always agree. And **nobody's score is ever worked out for them:** if someone's own answer is missing, the total waits.

The stress tank: How much are you carrying?

You score five things from 0 (not at all) to 4 (very true), about the last day or two: sleep debt, workload elsewhere, unresolved conflict, your physical state, and time pressure today.

```
tank = (sleep + workload + conflict + body + time) ÷ 20
```

The answer runs from 0 to 1, and **higher means fuller**. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 medium, and 0.60 or more high. (The worksheet splits each band in two for its words: very light under 0.15, light, medium on the lighter side under 0.45, medium on the heavier side, high under 0.80, and very high from 0.80.) Your **battery** is the other side of the same thing, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery. The battery is a picture in words, not a second score.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosa, from Part Two, Chapter III, page , scores sleep 3, workload 4, conflict 1, body 2 and time 3.

`3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 = 13; 13 ÷ 20 = 0.65`, which is in the high band.

Two or more of you: each person scores only themselves, and the shared figure is the plain average of everyone's own scores. If any one person is at 0.60 or more, treat that as the headline, whatever the average says.

Coming back after a pause (the Calm-Down Kit): if you like numbers, take the score again after a calming round. Under 0.50, go back at the time you named. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or more after two rounds, put it off to a named

time. The kit's line sits at 0.50 on purpose: you don't need an empty tank to come back, just one less than half full.

My weather today: the room in your day

My weather today shows words, not numbers: a sky (clear, gusty or fogged in) and how much room you have today. Behind the words sits a rough tally from 0 to 100, where **higher means a heavier day**. You only see it if you tick "Show the numbers behind this."

WHAT YOU PICKED	ADDS
The sky: clear, gusty, fogged in	0, 26, 34
The pressure: light, building, heavy (skipped: 6)	0, 10, 20
Last night's sleep: properly rested, about enough, short night, barely slept (skipped: 6)	0, 2, 10, 18
People load: barely any, a normal amount, a lot, nonstop (skipped: 4)	0, 3, 9, 14
Ground conditions (hungry, thirsty, in pain and so on)	4 each, up to 14
What's blowing in (work, money, health and so on)	3 each, up to 10

Under 45 reads as lots of room today, 45 to 64 as some room, and 65 or more as very little room.

WORKED EXAMPLE Joel, from Part One, Now, page , picks gusty, building pressure, a short night, a lot of people time, one ground condition (hungry) and one thing blowing in (work).

`26 + 10 + 10 + 9 + 4 + 3 = 62`: some room today, with less than usual, so the forecast says to go gently and settle first.

Workload balance: how evenly the hours are shared

Two people. Work out each person's share of the logged hours as a percentage.

```
balance = 1 − (the difference between the two percentages ÷ 100)
```

50/50 scores 1.00; one person doing everything scores 0.00. It doesn't matter which of you does more. Balance ignores the total, which is one reason the stress

tank sits beside it.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary logs 14 hours and Ken 10 (Part Two, Chapter II, page **18**). Out of 24 hours, that is 58.3% and 41.7%.

`1 − (58.3 − 41.7) ÷ 100 = 1 − 0.167 = 0.83`

Three or more people, or an agreed split. The same idea, said more generally: how much of the week would have to change hands to reach the target, compared with the most that ever could.

```
each share = that person's hours ÷ everyone's hours
target     = an even share (1 ÷ number of people), or the split you
agreed
moved      = ½ × the sum of every |share − target|
most       = 1 − the smallest target share
balance    = 1 − moved ÷ most
```

WORKED EXAMPLE Three partners log 15, 9 and 6 hours (Chapter II, page **18**): shares 0.50, 0.30 and 0.20, against a third each.

`moved = ½ × (0.167 + 0.033 + 0.133) = 0.167, most = 1 − 0.333 = 0.667, and balance = 1 − 0.167 ÷ 0.667 = 0.75`. In hours, 0.167 × 30 = 5 hours a week would change hands for an even split.

With an agreed split, use it as the target: co-parents who agreed 60/40 and log 12 and 8 hours score 1.00.

Ownership: does every job have a name?

```
ownership = jobs with a named owner ÷ all the jobs on the list
```

The calculator counts a job as owned when it has one named owner. A backstop, the person who notices if it slipped, is a good habit and has its own column, but the score only needs the owner. The starter jobs on the worksheet don't count until you give them an owner or change them. Never raise the score by deleting the jobs nobody owns: they are exactly what the score is there to show.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken list 12 regular jobs, and 9 have an owner: `9 ÷ 12 = 0.75`.

Who carries more of the list. A score of 1.00 can still mean one person owns everything, so One owner per job also shows each person's share of the list, with each job weighted by how often it comes round and how big it is:

```
weight of a job = how often × size
how often: daily 5, weekly 1, ongoing 1, monthly 0.25, as needed 0.1
size:      small 0.5, medium 1 (the default), big 2
           (or, where you gave the hours each time: hours ÷ 0.5)
share      = the weights of that person's jobs ÷ the weights of all
the jobs
```

A job you decide together counts the same for each of you; on a list for two homes it shows as "Together" instead.

WORKED EXAMPLE One person owns the cooking (daily, medium: 5) and the bills (monthly, medium: 0.25). The other owns the laundry (weekly, big: 2) and the car (as needed, medium: 0.1). Each owns two jobs, but `5.25 ÷ 7.35 = 71%` of the list's weight sits with the first person, and 29% with the second.

Who's carrying more right now. Who did what flags the busiest person when their share of the logged minutes (or of the work done without being asked) is at least half, and at least 20 points over an even share: 70% or more for two people, 53% or more for three. In the example in the Preface, page , one partner did 105 of the 115 minutes that were noticed and handled without anyone asking: 91%, so the sheet says so.

The setup score: can the way you share the work last?

```
setup score = balance × 0.40
            + ownership × 0.35
            + (1 − the average tank score) × 0.25
```

The weights add up to 1, so the score runs from 0 to 1, and here **higher means the setup is working better**, the opposite of the tank score. The tank is the only part that counts against the score, which is why it enters as 1 − tank. 0.70 or more reads as working well (the "Who does what?" page says "holding"). From 0.40 up to 0.70 it

reads as needs a look ("drifting"), and below 0.40 as needs a rethink, together. It is a snapshot of the setup, never a probability and never a verdict on anyone.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken (Chapter II, page **18**): balance 0.83, ownership 0.75, and their own tank scores are 0.45 and 0.30, an average of 0.375.

`0.83 × 0.40 + 0.75 × 0.35 + (1 − 0.375) × 0.25 = 0.333 + 0.263 + 0.156 = 0.75`: working well.

The shortfall is what each part could have earned minus what it did earn: balance 0.40 − 0.333 = 0.067, ownership 0.35 − 0.263 = 0.088, and tank 0.25 − 0.156 = 0.094. The biggest shortfall is the tank, which usually eases outside the chore list (more sleep, a lighter week elsewhere). The calculator's "what would help most" is the single change with the biggest gain: handing about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken would take balance from 0.83 to 1.00, worth 0.067. Naming one more job's owner would be worth 0.029, and a tank score lower by 0.10 on average 0.025.

The overall score adds a fourth part, retuning: of the moments that landed badly this week, how many you retuned before answering.

```
overall = balance × 0.35 + ownership × 0.30 + (1 − tank) × 0.20 +
retuning × 0.15
(no rough moments this week: leave retuning out, and divide the first
three parts by 0.85)
```

In Chapter II's first worked example (balance 0.60, ownership 0.80, an average tank score of 0.40, and 3 of 5 rough moments retuned): `0.21 + 0.24 + 0.12 + 0.09 = 0.66`.

The 30-day look-back: what shifted this month?

The look-back splits the last 30 days into four weeks (the first takes the first ten days). For each part you filled in (balance, ownership, the stress tank, and last-minute rescues), it compares the start of the month with the end:

```
start = the average of weeks 1 and 2
end   = the average of weeks 3 and 4
it shifted if end − start is 0.10 or more (balance, ownership, tank),
           or 1 a week or more (rescues); anything smaller didn't
shift
```

One next step: a part that moved the wrong way comes first (the biggest move for its size). Otherwise, the first of these that is still true at the end: ownership under 0.70, balance under 0.70, 2 or more rescues a week, or anyone's tank at 0.60 or more. If none is, keep the same rhythm and look again in 30 days.

Hours to change hands over the month: for each person, the hours they did minus their share of everyone's hours, added up week by week. Half the sum of those gaps (ignoring the minus signs) is how many hours would change hands to make the month even.

WORKED EXAMPLE Suppose Rosemary and Ken keep going for a month (made up, like them). Their four weeks look like this. Hours: 14 and 10, 15 and 9, 13 and 11, 12 and 12. Jobs with an owner: 9, 9, 11 and 11 of 12. Rosemary's tank: 0.45, 0.50, 0.40 and 0.35, and Ken's 0.30 every week. Rescues: 3, 2, 1 and 1.

PART	START (WEEKS 1–2)	END (WEEKS 3–4)	CHANGE	READS AS
Balance	(0.83 + 0.75) ÷ 2 = 0.79	(0.92 + 1.00) ÷ 2 = 0.96	+0.17	Better
Ownership	0.75	0.92	+0.17	Better
Average tank score	0.39	0.34	−0.05	About the same
Rosemary's own tank	0.48	0.38	−0.10	Lighter
Rescues a week	2.5	1	−1.5	Fewer

Three of the four parts shifted, all for the better, and nothing is left on the watch list, so the next step is to keep the rhythm. The setup score went from 0.73 to 0.87. Over the month Rosemary did 54 hours and Ken 42, so 6 hours would have changed hands for an even month.

On your own: is your week sustainable?

The “Who does what?” page’s “just me” view adds up the hours your week is spoken for (jobs, the thinking work, care and so on) and compares them with a waking week of about 112 hours (16 waking hours, 7 days).

```
share = the hours spoken for ÷ 112
```

Under 50% reads as sustainable, 50% up to 70% as full but workable, and 70% or more as stretched. For example, 50 hours spoken for is 45%, which leaves real room; 80 hours is 71%, a lot to keep up week after week.

All of these are this book’s own ways of putting things into numbers. They have not been tested in research studies, and they shouldn’t be quoted as findings. The free calculators on the website do the arithmetic for you, and each one has a “How is this worked out?” note.

Blank worksheets

Photocopy or print these pages, as many times as you like, and fill them out by hand. Each one is a blank copy of a worksheet in the book. The free fillable versions on the website do the sums for you, and keep what you type on your own device.

Who did what

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01.html

Write down what actually happened this week, before anyone starts remembering it as a story. Write down only what you did or saw yourself; never fill in someone else's side for them.

Person A _____ Person B _____

Week beginning _____

Part A: Who did what, this week

One row for each task noticed or done, including the invisible ones: remembering, planning, booking, forms. Time spent only thinking, noticing or planning counts too: log it as "Thinking and planning."

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?

This week's totals

Person A: minutes (and %), of which noticed and handled without being asked _____

Person B: minutes (and %), of which noticed and handled without being asked _____

Workload balance score: 1 − (A% − B%, ignoring any minus sign) ÷ 100 = _____

Part B (optional), Kind ways to say no: say why the request is fair, say honestly what you have left, and offer something instead.

Describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it. How the score works: "How the numbers work," at the back.

How much are you carrying?

Fillable version: spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02.html

Fill this out on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it out for someone else.

Your name _____ Date _____

The checklist

Score each row based on how the last 24–48 hours have actually gone. Circle one: 0 = Not at all, 4 = Very true. Living with a long-term illness? Your physical row may always be high. That fills the tank; it isn't a mood.

	Not at all				Very true
Sleep debt (less rested than usual)	0	1	2	3	4
Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving)	0	1	2	3	4
Recent unresolved conflict (any source)	0	1	2	3	4
Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain)	0	1	2	3	4
Time pressure today specifically	0	1	2	3	4

How full is your stress tank?

Points (add the five circled numbers): _____ out of 20

Tank: points ÷ 20 = _____ out of 1.00

Higher means a fuller tank (and a lower battery). Under 0.30: light. 0.30 to 0.59: medium. 0.60 or more: high. Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour.

Optional

☐ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

Anything you want to name before talking

A high score is a way to press pause, not a way out. It means "let's come back to this tomorrow," not "this doesn't need to happen."

One owner per job

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03.html

Every regular job gets one owner, the person who does it and sees it through. If you like, add a helper or backup who pitches in, notices if it slips, or covers it on a bad week. List the invisible jobs too: forms, gifts, renewals, planning, appointments.

Date of this list

The split you agreed (optional)

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup (optional)	Size (optional)	Notes

How often: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, As needed, Ongoing. Size: Small, Medium, Big.

Does every job have an owner?

Jobs with an owner: _____ of _____ = _____ out of 1.00

Changes to the list (optional)

Date	What changed	Who

Where we've landed

Agreeing means everyone has read this version and knows who owns what. It doesn't mean every job feels perfectly fair, only that ownership is clear.

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

What keeps coming back?

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04.html

A monthly look-back, done together, across four weeks of Who did what and One owner per job. It looks for the tasks that keep slipping. You're looking for where the setup needs a fix. Nobody is adding up what anyone owes.

Month

Part A: Gather the month's notes

List every task that was noticed but not done, or done only after being raised more than once. Mark an ✗ for each week it came up.

Task	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Times flagged

Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more. A **structural gap** has no clear owner (fix One owner per job now). A **capacity issue** has an owner who can't keep up (set a time for an honest conversation). A **one-off** has a temporary cause (note it and move on).

Task	Named owner on the job list? (Yes / No)	Classification	Action

Part C: Wrap up the audit

Structural gaps found

Capacity issues found

One-offs

Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?

Job	Gets thanked (Often / Sometimes / Rarely / Never)	Only noticed when missed? (Yes / No)	One way to notice it

Not a bill for the past, and not a performance review. A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person who kept covering it.

Say it so it lands

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09.html

A self-check each of you uses on your own side of a conversation. Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Your name _____ Date _____

Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

Raw reaction (optional, and just for you)

What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.) For example: "The trash went out late on Tuesday."

What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…) A feeling about you, not a verdict about them.

What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?) Something the other person can say yes to.

Before you react: four quick checks

Check	Circle one
Is this about a specific, nameable task or event?	Yes · No
Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot?	Yes · No · Not sure
Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said?	Yes · No
Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation?	Their words · A past pattern

A "No" or "Not sure" on the second check, a "Yes" on the third or "A past pattern" on the fourth are good reasons to pause first. A kind "not right now" and a time to come back keep it honest.

The Calm-Down Kit

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11.html

A short plan, made ahead of time, for calming your body down enough to have the conversation, or to put it off honestly. Fill in Part A on an ordinary day, not a hard one. Your kit is yours; only the pause plan is made to share.

Whose kit is this? (your name) _____ Date _____

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first

Part A: My two defaults

Pick two calming steps now: asymmetric breathing (breathe in for 4, out for 6) · naming the room (5 things you see, 4 you hear, 3 you can touch) · weight and pressure (feet pressed firmly into the floor, or something warm held in both hands) · gating (cutting noise and light: lower the lights, step out) · walking it out · a low, steady sound.

First default _____ Second, if the first isn't available _____

Part A: My pause line

Say how you are, how long you need, and when you'll be back: "I'm at capacity. I need ten minutes. I'll be back at a quarter after."

_____

Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal _____ The shortest break we take _____

How we set the time to come back _____ The first sentence when we come back _____

Part B, in the moment: say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step.

Part C: Coming back

Still hot? Another round. Twice? Name a new time. Settled enough to listen? Go back at the time you named. (For number fans: your stress tank score, 0 to 1. Under 0.50, go back. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or above after two rounds, put it off.)

Time	What I did	How I feel now (Still hot / Settled enough)	Stress tank before (0–1)	Stress tank after (0–1)

Next small action _____ If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up _____

Where I've landed

☐ I'm going with this

Look at this again on (optional) _____

Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

The 90-second daily check-in

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13.html

Each person answers each prompt in one sentence, about their own day, and fills in only their own rows. No debating, no solving, no arguing back. Anything that needs a real discussion waits for the weekly catch-up.

Week beginning

Each day

Day	Person	Stress tank (Light / Medium / High)	One thing I appreciated today	One small thing that didn't feel great	One thing that would help tomorrow
Mon					
Mon					
Tue					
Tue					
Wed					
Wed					
Thu					
Thu					
Fri					
Fri					
Sat					
Sat					
Sun					
Sun					

The weekly catch-up (optional)

Skim the week for anything that came up more than twice, and move it to the right worksheet.

Sore spot that keeps coming up	Times this week	Move to (One owner per job / Say it so it lands / Keep watching)

Where we've landed

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

Same moment, different speeds

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-12.html

For a few moments that come over often, each person marks how fast they want to move, how much they want to talk, and how urgent it feels. Each person fills in only their own rows, ideally before looking at the other's. There are no right answers.

Date

Part A: Each person's speed

Speed: right away · within the hour · later the same day · after a night's sleep. Talk: quiet time first · a few words, then act · talk it all through. Urgency: low · medium · high.

Moment	Person	Speed	Talk	Urgency	What helps me (optional)
A plan changes at the last minute					
A bill, letter or form needs dealing with					
Something breaks or goes wrong at home					
One of us is upset about something					
Deciding what to do with free time					

Part B: Where your speeds differ

For each moment, count how many steps apart your answers are on each list. Start with the biggest gap: a difference in pace, not in how much anyone cares.

Part C: One small agreement

Moment	What we'll try	Try it until

Where we've landed

Agreeing means you have both seen the gaps and will try the agreement. It doesn't mean either of you has to change speed for good.

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

Not a compatibility test and not a diagnosis. Run it again every few months, or after a big change.

Is it us, or is it everything else?

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-14.html

A one-week log that keeps two things apart: pressure from outside (money, work, health, sleep, family) and friction that really starts between you. A line or two each evening, each person about their own day. Write what happened, not who was wrong.

Week beginning

Part A: Each evening

Day	Person	Outside pressure today (None / A little / A lot)	Where it came from	A tense moment between us (if any)	Looking back, it was mostly (Outside pressure / Between us / Some of both / Not sure yet)
Mon					
Mon					
Tue					
Tue					
Wed					
Wed					
Thu					
Thu					
Fri					
Fri					
Sat					
Sat					
Sun					
Sun					

Part B: The week at a glance

Tense moments on heavy days: _____ of _____

Part C: What got blamed on the wrong thing?

The moment	What it seemed to be about	What was really going on	What would help next time

Part D: One plan for the pressure

The pressure we're facing right now

How we'll flag a heavy day

What we'll go easy on until it passes

One bit of outside help we could ask for (optional)

Outside pressure explains a hard day. It doesn't excuse unkindness, and it doesn't make what anyone felt less real.

Keep your little rituals alive

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15.html

Every three months or so, a short look at the small shared habits that keep you close: the morning coffee, the Sunday walk, the birthday breakfast. Nobody is to blame for one that lapsed.

Date

Part A: Our rituals, big and small

How it's doing: Alive (still happening, still means something) · Fading (on autopilot or less often) · Stopped · New idea. How often: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, Yearly, Now and then.

Ritual or habit	How often	How it's doing	What it gives us, or what got in the way

Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual

The smallest version that still counts

The first time: when, and who will suggest it

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)

Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks

The ritual

What it gave us

Where we've landed

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

A ritual is something you would both miss, not a test of love. Look at this sheet again in about three months.

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. More at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Alexithymia

Finding it hard to notice, name or describe your own feelings. It is a trait on a scale, not an illness, and it is more common in some autistic people. Naming body signals first can help.

Backstop

The second name on a job: someone who notices if it slipped and checks in kindly. Not a supervisor. A job counts as owned once it has an owner; the backstop is a good habit on top.

Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, how full your stress tank is: a fuller tank means a lower battery.

For example: After a poor night and a long workday, your stress tank is nearly full and your battery is low, so a small request feels big.

A bid

A bid is any small reach for attention or connection, like "look at this," a sigh or a joke.

For example: They show you a photo of a dog. Looking and smiling back is turning toward it.

Calm-Down Kit

Your Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

For example: A glass of cold water, a walk to the corner, and three long breaths out.

Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

For example: "Load today: heavy. Thank you for the dishes. One small thing: the car. My ask: could you fill it up?"

Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

For example: "How was your day?" "Fine." Months go by and nobody has asked a real question.

Double empathy

The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

Drift

Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

For example: Three busy weeks, no real talk, and small things start to feel big.

Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

For example: "I need twenty minutes. Can we talk again at eight?"

Frequency

Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

For example: One person answers a text in a minute; the other answers at the end of the day. Neither is wrong.

Gatekeeping

Holding on to how a home or child-care job must be done, so the other person steps back. Researchers first described it in mothers ("maternal gatekeeping"), but anyone can do it.

Groupthink

When a close group wants agreement so much that doubts go unsaid and a poor decision goes ahead. Irving Janis named it in 1972.

If-then plan

A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that," which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

A kind no

A kind no says what you can and can't do right now, without blaming anyone.

For example: "I can't take that on this week. I could help on Saturday."

Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

Ledger

A notebook where you write down what happened, so you can look at it calmly later. The book works the same way: see what is really going on, without blame, then change one small thing.

The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

For example: Buying the gift is one job. Remembering the birthday, picking the gift and wrapping it are three more.

Masking

Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

For example: Forcing eye contact and rehearsing small talk all day, then needing the evening to recover.

Mental load

The noticing, planning and remembering behind running a shared life: knowing the shoes are too small, booking the appointment, keeping the list. It is real work, even though nobody sees it.

Monotropism

A theory of autistic attention: attention gathers deeply on a few things at a time, rather than spreading thinly across many. Switching away can take real effort.

My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

For example: Short night, busy day: the forecast says to keep big talks for tomorrow.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

For example: Sam owns the recycling: noticing it's full, taking it out and buying the bags.

Parallel parenting

Co-parenting with as little direct contact as possible: each home runs its own way, and messages stay short, polite and about the children.

Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

For example: A pressure of 40 leaves room in the day; 75 means go gently and leave big things for later.

Prolonged grief

Grief that stays intense and gets in the way of daily life for a long time after a death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline). It is treatable.

Psychological safety

A shared sense in a group or team that you can speak up, ask a question or admit a mistake without being punished or embarrassed (Amy Edmondson).

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

For example: "I said that badly. What I meant was…"

Retune

To retune is to notice you've fallen out of step with someone and adjust together: slower, softer, or at a better time.

For example: "Can we start that again? I came in too fast."

The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

For example: "Whoever notices the mess cleans it" was the rule at home, so a messy kitchen feels like "It's always me."

Rumination

Going over the same worry or regret again and again without getting closer to an answer.

Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

For example: You ask "When will you do it?" calmly. They hear pressure. Nobody meant harm, but it crackles.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Turning toward

Turning toward means answering someone's small bids for attention, even briefly, instead of missing or brushing them off.

For example: "Oh, that's a funny one!" instead of scrolling on.

Unbilled debt

Unbilled debt is the work of a shared life that got done but was never noticed or thanked.

For example: You remembered the dentist appointment, and nobody knew there was anything to remember.

Wave Code

Four letters from the style quiz in How you connect, one for each of four preferences about how you take in and send words. Each letter shows where you lean on a dial today: a shorthand for preferences, not a personality type.

Window of tolerance

The range in which you can feel strong feelings and still think and talk. Above it you are flooded or revved up; below it you shut down. A phrase from the psychiatrist Dan Siegel.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

For example: A hint like "the trash are full" may be heard as a plain fact, not a request.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

For example: Some people need a plan in writing. Others think best out loud.

Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill out on the website.

For example: "Who did what" is a week's log of who did what.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

For example: "Rest is earned" can feel like plain fact, until you notice it was your family's rule.

List of figures

Figure 1 How the three parts fit together · *Front of the book* 13

Figure 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on · *Front of the book* 14

Figure 13 Is the split working? · *Is the split working?* 21

List of filled-in examples

Example 8 — Who does what? Quick look · *Wren, Josh and Mei, roommates (Wren's view) · Is the split working?* 22

Example 9 — Is the setup working for everyone? · *Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years · Is the split working?* 26

Example 10 — Our room agreement · *Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates · Is the split working?* 30

Example 11 — Who did what, with small children · *Hollie and Gareth, parents of a toddler and a baby; Gareth works shifts · Is the split working?* 33

Research notes

The 447 studies and books the chapters mention, chapter by chapter, each with what it found in plain words and where to read it. Each entry was looked up and checked: most against the paper itself or its abstract, some (mostly older books) against a publisher's or library's record. Unchecked works are left out. The full list, with notes on how strong each finding is, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Reading research: a few words in plain English

The chapters often say how sure the research is: "a small study," "linked with," "didn't replicate." Here is what those words mean, so every note in the book is something you can weigh for yourself.

Correlational ("linked with")
Two things tend to go together: people who sleep less tend to argue more. It doesn't show which causes which, or whether a third thing, like a new baby, causes both.

Experiment
Researchers change one thing on purpose, ideally deciding by chance who gets it, and compare. Better at showing cause, though often in a lab, for a short time, with a small group.

Meta-analysis
A study of studies: it pools many studies of the same question. Usually more trustworthy than any one study, but only as good as the studies in it.

Replication
Doing a study again to see if the result holds. When a large team re-ran 100 published psychology studies in 2015, only about a third gave a clear result again, and the effects were on average about half as big. So one study is a start, not the end.

Effect size
How big a difference is, not just whether there is one. A result can be real ("significant") and still tiny. The book says "small" or "modest" when that is the case.

Who was studied
Much of psychology studies students in Western, educated, well-off countries. A finding may not fit every age, culture or kind of family, and many studies of couples looked only at a mother and a father.

Self-report
People answered questions about themselves. That is often the only way to ask about feelings, but memory and wanting to look good both creep in.

How the book labels things: a *Research note* describes published findings in plain words and says where the evidence is thin. *This site's idea* marks the book's own ways of putting things into practice, such as the worksheets and the setup score, which have not been tested in studies. The full list at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research also says how strong each finding is: strong, moderate or early.

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

Is the split working?

Cohen, S., Kamarck, T., & Mermelstein, R. (1983). A *global measure of perceived stress.* Journal of Health and Social Behavior, 24(4), 385–396. Introduced the Perceived Stress Scale, a short questionnaire about how unpredictable, uncontrollable and overloaded your life has felt lately; scores went with symptoms of depression and illness.
doi.org/10.2307/2136404

Cowan, C. P., & Cowan, P. A. (1992). *When Partners Become Parents: The Big Life Change for Couples.* BasicBooks (New York); reissued 1999 (Erlbaum) and 2011. Based on the Becoming a Family Project, a long-term study of expectant couples, describes how strain and conflict between partners commonly rise across the transition to parenthood, and tests couples groups as prevention.
openlibrary.org/works/OL92708W

Daminger, A. (2019). *The cognitive dimension of household labor.* American Sociological Review, 84(4), 609–633. Interviews with 35 couples (70 interviews) identified four parts of household "cognitive labor": anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding, and monitoring. Women did more of it overall, especially anticipating and monitoring; deciding was shared more equally. The work was often unseen by both partners.
doi.org/10.1177/0003122419859007

Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968). *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

di Leonardo, M. (1987). *The female world of cards and holidays: Women, families, and the work of kinship.* Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society, 12(3), 440–453. Named "kin work": the cards, calls, visits, gifts and gatherings that keep extended families connected. In the families she studied, it was done mostly by women and often treated as effortless.
doi.org/10.1086/494338

Doss, B. D., Rhoades, G. K., Stanley, S. M., & Markman, H. J. (2009). *The effect of the transition to parenthood on relationship quality: An 8-year prospective study.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 96(3), 601–619. Following 218 couples over the first eight years of marriage, those who had a first child showed sudden declines in relationship quality after the birth, on average, compared with couples who did not.
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